

Dvar Torah Outline — Hallel HaGadol, the Fifth Cup, and Why Sustenance Surpasses Redemption (Rabbi Shulman)

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman explains the closing progression of *Hallel HaGadol*—from Hashem remembering us in our lowliness, to redeeming us from our oppressors, and culminating in Hashem providing food to all flesh. He develops the Maharal's idea (based on Pesachim) that **פרנסה** is “greater” than **גאולה** because it is the ongoing, direct divine sustaining of all existence without intermediaries. This frames the **fifth cup** at the Seder as a (non-obligatory) elevation beyond the four cups of redemption, tied to *Hallel HaGadol* and to a deeper structure of “four directions” unified by a “fifth” central point.

I. Reading the end of Hallel HaGadol: from lowliness to redemption to sustenance

A. “In our lowliness He remembered us”

- Rabbi Shulman focuses on: “שבשפלנו זכר לנו כי לעולם חסדו” (In our lowliness He remembered us, for His kindness is eternal).
- Clarification of *שפלות*:
 - Not that Israel is inherently low.
 - Rather, lowliness is a consequence of **חטאים**, creating a fallen state from which Hashem still “remembers” us.

B. Next step: Hashem removes oppression

- “ויפרקנו מצרינו כי לעולם חסדו” (He freed us from our oppressors, for His kindness is eternal).
- Rabbi Shulman presents it as moving upward from “remembering us in lowliness” to actively “throwing off” our suffering.

C. The “capstone”: Hashem provides food to all

- “נותן לחם לכל בשר כי לעולם חסדו” (He gives bread to all flesh, for His kindness is eternal).
 - The central claim: this final **חסד** is listed last because it is **more elevated** than the miracles of redemption.
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II. Why “נותן לחם לכל בשר” is greater than redemption (3:00)

A. Gemara in Pesachim: sustenance is “harder” than redemption

- Rabbi Shulman cites: אמר רבי אלעזר קשים מזונותיו של אדם יותר מן הגאולה (R. Elazar said: a person's sustenance is “harder” than redemption).
- Contrast in verses (as framed in the transcript):
 - Redemption can be via a מלאך (בעלמא). (“מלאך בעלמא”)
 - Sustenance is expressed as direct divine shepherding: “האלקים הרועה אותי מעודי” (Hashem shepherds/provides for me from the beginning).

B. What does “קשים” mean if nothing is hard for Hashem?

- Rabbi Shulman answers using the Maharal's approach (paralleling “וינפש”):
 - “Hard” doesn't mean Hashem struggles.
 - It means: from **our perspective**, it is a greater חידוש / more profound reality.
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III. Sustenance as direct חיים: the heart-and-limbs model (8:30)

A. Analogy: the heart gives life to every limb directly

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's metaphor:
 - Every limb receives חיות from the heart **directly**, not through other limbs.
 - He illustrates it like a **parallel** (not series) circuit: each recipient is connected to the source independently.

B. Nimshal: all beings receive life from Hashem without intermediaries

- “וכך כל הנמצאים כולם מקבלים חיות מן השם יתברך תחילה בלי אמצעי” (So too all existents receive life from Hashem directly, without an intermediary).
- Key equation highlighted in the transcript:
 - “ומפני שהמזנות גם כן חיותו של אדם” (Since sustenance is also a person's life...)
 - Therefore, sustenance too is sourced directly from Hashem.

C. Addressing the conceptual question: “food” vs. “life”

- Rabbi Shulman notes an implicit blending:
 - .because without it one cannot live חיים is not merely “material”—it is bound up with מזון
 - He suggests a framing: the physical bread is a **vessel** that carries the sustaining vitality.
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IV. From this framework: why Chazal instituted a fifth cup (20:00)

A. Four cups = gratitude for redemption; fifth cup = gratitude for ongoing sustenance

- Rabbi Shulman summarizes the Maharal:
 - **Four cups** correspond to the **four expressions of redemption**.
 - After that comes “completing” Hashem’s kindness: **קיום והפרנסה**—the sustaining of creation.

B. Why it’s a “רשות,” not an obligation

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - The four cups are essential to the night’s theme of גאולה, so they are obligatory (rabbinically).
 - The fifth cup reflects a subtler, loftier recognition—ongoing providence—so it is **optional**, though still a mitzvah if done:
 - “אבל בוודאי מצוה איכא” (There is certainly a mitzvah aspect).

C. Practical placement issue (Maharal vs. printed Haggadah)

- Rabbi Shulman notes a tension:
 - The standard printed Haggadah follows the Tur’s structure (placing *Hallel HaGadol* within what is said on the 4th cup).
 - The Maharal insists the whole logic points to *Hallel HaGadol* belonging on the **5th cup**.
 - Proposed Maharal-aligned sequence (in theory):
 1. Complete Hallel and **ברכת השיר** on cup #4.
 2. Pour cup #5.
 3. Say **הלל הגדול** on cup #5.
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V. The deeper structure: “four” as worldly multiplicity, “five” as unifying center (27:00)

A. Geulah as descent from the transcendent into the world of nature

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's metaphysical language:
 - comes from **עולם הנבדל** (a transcendent plane) into **עולם הטבע / עולם הריבוי** (the world of multiplicity/nature).

B. Why redemption manifests as “four”

- When the abstract becomes physical, it spreads into **four directions**:
 - Hence **four expressions of redemption** and **four cups**.

C. Why “five” is higher: the center that unites the four

- The **fifth** represents the unifying middle point that holds the four together:
 - “**כי החמישי הוא מאחד את הארבע**” (the fifth unites the four).
 - Rabbi Shulman adds the Maharal's idea that the unifying middle has a **higher מדרגה**, because it connects back to the transcendent source.
 - Fifth cup aligns with this:
 - Sustenance/continuity is a “central,” overarching divine relationship that is **above** the category of redemption.
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VI. Why loftier truths are less “obligatory”: the principle of **רשות** vs. **חיוב** (33:01)

A. Maharal's key rule

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes:
 - **חיוב** applies to realities that are **קרובים**—immediately evident and accessible.
 - Loftier, more “distant” truths are not demanded as obligations; they are offered as **רשות** (optional mitzvah).

B. Examples Rabbi Shulman uses to illustrate

- **Kiddush at night vs. daytime Kiddush**:
 - The entrance of shabbat is obvious and demands sanctification.
 - A “higher level” recognition is less obvious, so it may be less obligatory.

- **Birkat HaMazon** framework:

- Some blessings are obligatory; other praises reflect higher recognitions that Chazal may highlight for us.

C. Back to the core question: why say Hallel HaGadol on the 4th cup?

- Rabbi Shulman concludes this section with the Maharal's challenge:
 - If *Hallel HaGadol* expresses the pinnacle—Hashem's sustaining of all—then it belongs on the **fifth cup**, not the fourth.
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In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman traces *Hallel HaGadol's* closing ladder: Hashem remembers us in sin-born lowliness, redeems us from oppressors, and culminates with giving food to all.
- Based on Pesachim and the Maharal, **פרנסה** is “greater than גאולה” because it is **constant, direct divine חיים** without intermediaries.
- The heart-to-limbs (parallel) model illustrates how each being receives sustenance/life straight from Hashem.
- The **fifth cup** corresponds to this higher recognition (פרנסה), making it a **רשות**—a mitzvah opportunity beyond the obligatory four cups of redemption.
- A “four-and-five” structure underlies the concept: four directions of worldly multiplicity unified by a higher fifth center, mirroring how sustenance transcends redemption.